

3.2.5 2E Judaism

Students are required to study those aspects of the religious beliefs, teachings, values and practices of Judaism specified below and the different ways in which these are expressed in the lives of individuals, communities and societies.

They should develop a knowledge and critical understanding of:

- the specified material
- how the texts specified for study are interpreted and applied
- the influence of beliefs and teachings on individuals, communities and societies
- the causes, meanings and significance of similarities and differences in religious thought belief and practice within Judaism
- approaches to the study of religion and belief.

They should be able to analyse and evaluate issues arising from the topics studied, and the views and arguments of the scholars prescribed for study.

Questions may be set that span more than one topic.

Students may study any version of the specified texts, but should be aware of issues related to translation where relevant. Quotations will not be used in questions.

Students should be able to use specialist language and terminology appropriately.

Exam questions will show a translation for any non-English terms (except for names of people, texts and schools of thought). However students are expected to recognise and understand the following technical terms: 'Eternal Thou', She'ol, pikuach nephesh, agunot, minyan.

Section A: Judaism

Sources of wisdom and authority

- The Tenakh: different Jewish beliefs about the nature and authority of the Tenakh, including: as the absolute Word of God, complete and unchangeable and as inspired by God but written by human beings; the influence of these beliefs on the way in which the Tenakh is used as a source of authority in worship and in everyday life.
- The Babylonian Talmud: different Jewish beliefs about its nature, authority and importance.
- Rabbis: their role and authority in contemporary Judaism, including reference to the Beth Din.

God

- Monotheism: God as one, eternal, omniscient and omnipotent creator and controller of all things; beliefs about God expressed in Maimonides' Thirteen Principles of the Faith.
- God as personal: the personal God of the Bible, and debates about how the anthropomorphic and gender based language about God should be interpreted, with particular reference to God as King and Father and Genesis 3:8.
- Martin Buber: key ideas about God in Martin Buber's theology: God as the 'Eternal Thou'; God known in and through personal human relationships.

Self, death and afterlife

- The meaning and purpose of life: different purposes of life and their relative importance: obedience; to bring the Messiah and to repair the world; different Jewish understandings of the Messianic Age.
- Life after death: In the Tenakh: including I Samuel 28:11–20 and the concept of She'ol; nature of the soul; resurrection of the flesh in the Thirteen Principles of the Faith and modern attitudes to this belief; immortality of the soul in later Jewish thinking including the expression of these beliefs in the Pittsburgh Platform; the link between belief in the afterlife and belief in the justice of God.
- Reincarnation in some kabbalistic thinking.

Good conduct and key moral principles

- Good moral conduct: the importance of good moral conduct in Judaism with reference to obedience to God and the mitzvot; and the extent of human freedom and moral responsibility; the place of individual reasoning and decision-making including the principle of pikuach nephesh.
- The sanctity of life: the concept of the sanctity of life and its application to issues concerning the embryo and the unborn child and war; issues including the use of weapons of mass destruction; different Jewish views on these issues.
- Stewardship: the concept of stewardship and Jewish attitudes to animals and the environment, and how changing understandings of the effects of human activities on the environment have affected that role.

Expressions of religious identity

- The concept of 'Jew', and different understandings of what it means to be a Jew, including: the importance of being born a Jewish mother; attitudes to circumcision and to bar/bat mitzvah.
- Expressions of Jewish identity in daily life: different attitudes to dress, keeping a kosher home and keeping Shabbat; expressions of Jewish identity in worship including the diversity of practice within synagogue worship, Yom Kippur and Pesach.
- The changing role of the synagogue in society with reference to its developments during the Exile in Babylon and its role today.

Judaism, gender and sexuality

Historical and social factors that have influenced developments in Jewish thinking about these issues including: the changing roles of men and women in society outside of religion; different understandings of the Torah and Halakah; the rights given to women by secular governments.

Developments in Jewish thought, including feminist approaches:

- Debates about the ordination of women as rabbis from c1970 to the present.
- The work of the Jewish Orthodox Feminist Alliance, including its views on the issues of agunot and minyan.
- Different Jewish views about celibacy, marriage, homosexuality and transgender issues, including the views of Rachel Adler.

Judaism and science

How and why science has influenced Judaism and how Judaism has responded, with particular reference to: science's emphasis on evidence and reason; specific scientific discoveries; science as a stimulus to Jewish ethical thinking.

Developments in Jewish thought:

- The importance of science: Maimonides: how contemplation of nature reveals the glory of God.
- How science can challenge religious beliefs; different Jewish responses to Darwin's theory of evolution and the Big Bang theory of the origin of the universe, including the views of Gerald Schroeder.
- Different Jewish responses to ethical issues raised by science: genetic engineering.

Judaism and the challenge of secularisation

The challenge of secularisation including: the replacement of religion as the source of truth and moral values; relegation of religion to the personal sphere; the rise of militant atheism: the view that religion is irrational and a threat to social stability.

Developments in Jewish thought:

- Ghettoism: the preservation of Jewish identity with reference to Nehemiah 10:28–31 alternative responses of assimilation and integration.
- Responses to materialistic secular values: the value of wealth and possessions.
- Different responses to the state of Israel including Political Zionism and Religious Zionism.
- Emphasis on the social relevance of Judaism: liberationist approaches as supporting the poor and defending the oppressed with reference to the Jewish Social Action Forum (JSAF).

Judaism, migration and religious pluralism

How migration has created multicultural societies which include Judaism, with particular reference to the development of Judaism in Britain; diversity within the Jewish community in Britain; freedom of religion as a human right in European law and religious pluralism as a feature of modern secular states. The influence of this context on Jewish thought.

Developments in Jewish thought:

- The concept of Pluralistic Judaism, its implications for relationships between the different traditions of Judaism and between Judaism and other faiths.
- Jewish understandings of their role as the chosen people and its implications for their relationship with other faiths.
- Jewish responses to issues of freedom of religious expression in society.

A comparison of the significant ideas in the post holocaust theology of Ignatz Maybaum and Richard Rubenstein: Maybaum – churban, remnant and suffering servant; Rubenstein: the 'death' of God and of the Covenant.

Section B: Dialogues

This section of the specification is focused on the connections between various elements of the course and requires students to develop breadth and depth in their understanding of the connections between the knowledge, understanding and skills set out in the specification. There are two areas for study, firstly the dialogue between Judaism and philosophy: how developments in belief have, over time, influenced and been influenced by philosophical studies of religion, secondly the dialogue between Judaism and ethics: how developments in belief have influenced and been influenced by ethical studies.

Students will be required to demonstrate a critical awareness of these connections and to analyse their nature.

The dialogue between Judaism and philosophy

Beliefs and teachings about:

- God
- self, death and afterlife
- sources of wisdom and authority
- religious experience
- the relationship between scientific and religious discourses
- the truth claims of other religions
- miracles.

The following issues, and the impact of the discussion on religious belief past and present, should be considered:

- How far the belief is reasonable – that is based on reason and/or consistent with reason.
- How meaningful the statements of faith are, and for whom.
- How coherent the beliefs are, and how consistent with other beliefs within the belief system.
- The relevance of philosophical enquiry for religious faith, with particular reference to the debate about the nature of faith as ‘belief in’ or ‘belief that’.

Two unstructured questions will be set. Students must answer one.

The dialogue between Judaism and ethics

- Jewish responses to the following approaches to moral decision-making in the light of key Jewish moral principles:
 - deontological, with reference to Kant.
 - teleological and consequential, with reference to Bentham.
 - character based, with reference to virtue ethics.
- How far Jewish ethics can be considered to be deontological, teleological, consequential, or character based.
- Jewish response to: the issues of human life and death and issues of animal life and death prescribed for study; theft and lying; marriage; homosexuality and transgender issues; genetic engineering.
- Jewish responses to issues surrounding wealth, tolerance and freedom of religious expression.
- Jewish understandings of free will and moral responsibility, and the value of conscience in Jewish moral decision-making.

The impact of other ethical perspectives and ethical studies on Jewish views about these issues, both past and present. This may include challenges to and support for Jewish views; compatibility of Jewish views with those of other ethical perspectives; the relative strengths and weaknesses of Jewish perspectives and the other ethical perspectives studied on these issues; the implications of criticisms of Jewish ethical teaching for the religion as a whole and its sources of authority.

Two unstructured questions will be set. Students must answer one.